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Hack and Slash Adventure for Fate's Edge: The Crimson Veil

Adventure Overview

Tier: II (Seasoned)

Theme: Ancient conspiracy, forbidden knowledge, and the price of power

Hooks: Missing scholar, haunted ruins, mysterious patron interest

Adventure Synopsis

The party is drawn into a web of ancient secrets when renowned scholar Quinn Thorne vanishes while investigating the ruins of Valdris Keep. What begins as a simple search mission becomes a deadly race against time as the party discovers that Thorne uncovered something that powerful forces will kill to keep buried.

Session 1: The Scholar's Last Request

Opening Scene: The Message

Cold Open: The party receives a sealed letter delivered by a nervous courier. The letter, written in Quinn Thorne's distinctive hand, contains a desperate plea for help and a cryptic warning about "the crimson veil that hides the truth of the ancient ones."

Key Information:

- tem Thorne was last seen at the ruins of Valdris Keep
- tem He mentions a "crimson sigil" and "voices from the deep"
- tem The letter is dated three days ago
- tem A strange symbol is drawn in the corner (Ikasha's mark)

Scene 1: Journey to Valdris Keep

Travel Timer : [4] segments

Travel Roles:

tem **Guide:** Navigate the treacherous mountain paths tem **Scout:** Watch for bandits and unnatural signs tem **Quartermaster:** Manage supplies in harsh conditions tem **Watch:** Stay alert for supernatural threats

Encounter Seeds:

- tem **Bandit Ambush (DV 3)** Wits + Notice or Melee + Athleticstem SB: Reinforcements arrive, supplies stolen, party split up tem Success: Bandits routed tem Partial: Escape but lose supplies tem Miss: Captured temporarily
- tem **The Whispering Woods (DV 4)** Wits + Lore or Spirit + Endurance
 - tem SB: Lose the path, hear disturbing voices, hallucinations tem Success: Navigate safely tem Partial: Take longer route tem Miss: Spend night in woods, gain Shaken condition
- tem **Supply Shortage Crisis** Resource management challenge
 - tem Party must make difficult choices about rationing tem Bonddriven decisions can provide bonuses

Scene 2: The Ruins of Valdris Keep

Location Overview:

Valdris Keep stands as a crumbling testament to a forgotten age. Built into the mountain-side, the fortress shows signs of both ancient construction and recent occupation. Strange symbols have been carved into the stone, and an unnatural chill permeates the air.

Key Areas:

- tem **The Outer Courtyard**tem Evidence of recent campfires and supplies tem Carved symbols matching those in Thorne's letter tem **Investigation Check (DV 3):** Wits + Investigationtem Success: Find Thorne's journal fragment tem Partial: Discover hidden entrance but alert guards tem Miss: Triggered alarm, hostile forces arrive
- tem **The Great Hall**
 - tem Massive chamber with a dais at the far end tem Ancient murals depicting ritual sacrifices tem **Notice Check (DV 4):** Wits + Noticetem Success: Spot hidden pressure plate tem Partial: Notice something is wrong but can't identify it tem Miss: Trigger trap, ceiling begins to collapse
- tem **Thorne's Study (Hidden Room)**
 - tem Scholar's makeshift laboratory with books and notes tem Partially burned documents tem **Lore Check (DV 3):** Wits + Loretem Success: Decipher key passages about the Crimson Veil ritual tem Partial: Get general idea but miss crucial details tem Miss: Documents too damaged, gain only fragments

Scene 3: The Cultists Arrive

Complication Timer : Cultist Arrival [6]

As the party explores the ruins, they attract unwanted attention. Members of the Crimson Veil cult, who have been tracking Thorne's research, arrive to claim what he discovered.

Combat Encounter: Cultist Skirmish

tem **Enemies:** 4 Cultists (Cap 1), 1 Cult Leader (Cap 2) tem **Environment:** Crumbling ruins with unstable sections tem **Position:** Start Controlled, shift based on actions tem **Key Tactics:** Cultists fight desperately to protect their secrets

Cultist Stats (Simplified):

tem **Cultist:** Melee 2, Body 2, Harm 1 tem **Cult Leader:** Melee 3, Body 3, Harm 2, +1 die vs. fear effects

Environmental Hazards:

tem **Unstable Ceiling:** When Leash fills on any combatant, rubble falls (Harm 1 to random target) tem **Ancient Glyphs:** Certain areas glow with protective magic when activated

Scene 4: The Crimson Veil Ritual

Climax: The cult leader attempts to complete a ritual using Thorne's research and the party's blood.

Ritual Timer : Crimson Veil Activation [8]

Key Elements:

tem **Interrupt the Ritual:** Multiple skill challenges tem **Protect Thorne:** He's found bound but alive tem **Survive Supernatural Forces:** The ritual begins to tear reality

Skill Challenges:

tem **Disrupt the Circle (DV 4):** Body + Athletics or Wits + Tinker tem **Break Thorne's Bonds (DV 3):** Wits + Tinker or Melee + Athletics tem **Counter the Summoning (DV 5):** Spirit + Arcana or Presence + Command

Supernatural Complications:

tem Reality distortions (Position shifts) tem Manifesting entities (additional combatants) tem Time pressure (timer advances rapidly)

Session 2: The Depths of Valdris

Opening: The Revelation

The failed ritual has awakened something deeper in the keep. The party discovers that Valdris Keep was built over an ancient prison, and the Crimson Veil cult has been working to free what lies beneath.

Scene 1: The Descent

Exploration Timer : Delving Deeper [6]

The party must navigate the ancient passages beneath the keep, facing both physical challenges and supernatural horrors.

Key Challenges:

- tem **The Spiral Staircase (DV 4):** Body + Athleticstem SB: Steps crumble, party separated, fall damage
- tem **The Guardian Statues (DV 5):** Wits + Lore
 - tem SB: Animated guardians attack, magical barriers activate
- tem **The Voice of the Deep (DV 4):** Spirit + Endurance
 - tem SB: Mind effects, hallucinations, temporary Harm

Scene 2: The Ancient Prison

Location: A vast chamber filled with crystalline structures that hum with otherworldly energy.

Key Discoveries:

- tem Thorne's complete research notes
- tem The true nature of the Crimson Veil (a prison seal)
- tem Evidence of previous attempts to break the seal
- tem A partially opened portal to another realm

Investigation Challenge (DV 4): Wits + Investigation

- tem Success: Understand how to reinforce the seal
- tem Partial: Get partial knowledge, must experiment dangerously
- tem Miss: Accidentally weaken the seal further

Scene 3: The Prisoner Awakens

Boss Encounter: The partially freed entity begins to manifest, testing the party's resolve and forcing them to make difficult choices.

Combat Stats:

tem **The Prisoner:** Cap 4, Harm 3, various supernatural abilities tem **Environmental Effects:** Reality distortions, summoned minions, time loops

Key Mechanics:

tem The entity grows stronger as the seal weakens tem Party can choose to reinforce the seal or destroy the entity tem Moral choices affect longterm consequences

Session 3: The Crimson Conspiracy

Opening: The Aftermath

The party's actions in Valdris Keep have consequences that ripple outward. They discover that the Crimson Veil cult is just one branch of a larger organization with influence in nearby settlements.

Scene 1: Return to Civilization

Social Challenge: Convincing authorities of the supernatural threat while dealing with cult infiltration.

Key NPCs:

tem **Magistrate Aldric:** Skeptical but fair local authority tem **Sister Miriam:** Local healer who knows more than she lets on tem **Captain Roderick:** Town guard captain with divided loyalties

Social Encounters:

tem **The Magistrate's Audience (DV 4):** Presence + Diplomacy tem **Gathering Allies (DV 3):** Presence + Command tem **Exposing the Infiltration (DV 5):** Wits + Insight

Scene 2: The Cult's Stronghold

Location: An abandoned monastery that serves as the cult's regional headquarters.

Infiltration Challenge (DV 4): Stealth + Subterfuge

tem Success: Gain access without alerting guards tem Partial: Get in but must move quickly tem Miss: Captured, must escape or negotiate

Key Areas:

tem **The Library:** Contains dangerous knowledge and magical artifacts tem **The Ritual Chamber:** Where the cult plans their next major ritual tem **The Prison Cells:** Where they keep unwilling participants

Scene 3: The Final Confrontation

Climactic Battle: The party faces the cult's leadership in a battle that will determine whether the Crimson Veil spreads or is contained.

Major NPCs:

tem **High Inquisitor Malachar:** Leader of the local cult branch tem **The Crimson Hand:** Elite cult warriors tem **Summoned Entities:** Supernatural beings bound to the cult's service

Environmental Challenges:

tem Active ritual circles that provide benefits to cultists tem Collapsing architecture due to supernatural strain tem Time pressure as the ritual nears completion

Adventure Rewards

Experience Awards

tem **Session 1 Completion:** 8 XP tem **Session 2 Completion:** 8 XP tem **Session 3 Completion:** 10 XP tem **Major Objectives:** +4 XP each tem **Hard Choices:** +2 XP each tem **Discovery:** +2 XP

Treasure and Magic Items

tem **Thorne's Research Notes:** Valuable lore item tem **Crimson Sigil Pendant:** Minor magical item (+1 to relevant skill checks) tem **Ancient Blade:** Weapon with special properties against supernatural foes tem **Protective Ward:** Can be used to reinforce seals tem **Cultist Cipher:** Allows understanding of cult communications

Story Consequences

tem **Patron Attention:** The party's actions may attract the notice of powerful entities tem **Reputation Changes:** How local communities view the party tem **Ongoing Threats:** The Crimson Veil may seek revenge tem **Allies and Enemies:** New relationships formed during the adventure

GM Notes and Variations

Scaling for Different Tiers

tem **Tier I:** Reduce enemy capabilities, simplify challenges tem **Tier III:** Add more complex encounters, higher stakes tem **Tier IV+:** Introduce cosmiclevel threats, world-

changing consequences

Optional Complications

tem **Thorne's Corruption:** The scholar may have been changed by his discoveries tem **Double Agents:** Some allies may have hidden cult connections tem **Time Loop:** The ritual creates temporal anomalies tem **Multiple Realities:** Different versions of events exist simultaneously

Integration with Campaign

This adventure can serve as:

tem A standalone story tem The beginning of a larger campaign against supernatural threats tem A character origin story that defines their relationship with power and responsibility tem A gateway to exploring the deeper magic system of Fate's Edge

Key Themes

tem **The Price of Knowledge:** Some truths come with terrible costs tem **Power and Corruption:** How far will characters go to protect what they value? tem **Sacrifice and Heroism:** What makes someone a hero in the face of impossible odds? tem **Ancient Secrets:** The past holds both wisdom and danger

This adventure provides a solid foundation for a threesession hack and slash campaign that explores both combat encounters and deeper thematic elements, while giving players meaningful choices that affect the outcome and their characters' development.